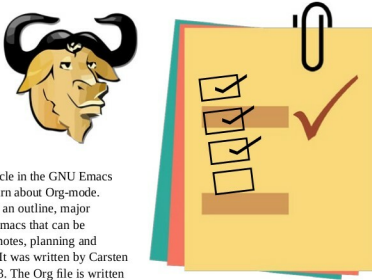


GNU Emacs: What's Org-Mode?

Keeping notes, maintaining to-do lists, planning projects and author documents with a fast and effective plain-text system – that's what Emacs Org-mode helps you do. There's even a mobile version available as FOSS so that your favourite note-taking tool remains with you always.



In this next article in the GNU Emacs series, let's learn about Org-mode.

Org-mode is an outline, major mode in GNU Emacs that can be used for taking notes, planning and documentation. It was written by Carsten Dominik in 2003. The Org file is written in plain text and markdown, and it can be exported into multiple output formats (TeX, HTML, PDF, etc). Org-mode ships with GNU Emacs, and this tutorial uses GNU Emacs 24.4.1 (M-x version) and Org-mode version 8.2.10 (M-x org-version).

Structure

An Org file ends with the .org file name extension. The top-level headlines are marked using an asterisk (*). For example, a college student may have the following high-level topics:

```
* College
* Home
* Recreation
```

You can create topics in the sub-section with more asterisks. For example:

```
* College
** Assignments
** Lab
** Exams
* Home
* Recreation
```

If you wish to hide the multiple asterisks at the sub-section level, you can add the following to your ~/.emacs:

```
(setq org-hide-leading-stars t)
```

The resultant Org file will look like what follows:

```
* College
* Assignments
* Lab
* Exams
* Home
* Recreation
```

You can add unnumbered (use the minus or plus symbols) or numbered lists as shown below:

```
* College
* Assignments
* Lab
  1. Compiler Design
  2. Programming Languages
* Exams
  - Mathematics
  - Operating Systems
  - Databases
  - Compilers
* Home
* Recreation
```

You can cycle through the various levels in the Org file using the **Tab** and **Shift-Tab** keys.

A checkbox with a '/' or a '%' symbol can be used next to a topic name to indicate the completion status of the task. The lists under a topic can each have a checkbox too. Using C-c C-c will mark a checkbox for completion ('X') and will also update the statistics in the top-level checkbox. An example is shown below:

```
* College...
* Home [2/2]
```